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BACKGROUND AND AIMS

Evidence on psychedelics comes mainly from controlled trials. In real-world use, post-acute anxiety and depression arising after a psychedelic experience remain underexamined, as does the role of motivations for use and stigma, especially in prohibitive contexts such as Italy.

Aim: Test whether motivations of use, motivational breadth, self-rated experience and perceived stigma are associated with the presence and burden of post-acute anxiety and depression.

METHODS

Sample: Italian subsample of the Global Psychedelic Survey 2025 (adults aged 21 or older, lifetime psychedelic use): 534 respondents for anxiety, 532 for depression.

Outcomes: post-acute anxiety and depression lasting over 24 hours after the acute effects, attributed to psychedelic use:

- Symptom presence (yes or no)
- Total Burden (0 to 1, average of duration and clinical impact, i.e. severity and functional interference).

Analysis: logistic regression for symptom presence (odds ratios); OLS regression with robust errors for Total Burden (β); FDR correction for motivational contrasts; sensitivity analysis with alternative index weightings.

Predictors: enhancement, therapeutic and recreational motivations (recreational as reference), motivational breadth, perceived stigma impact, age, sex, self-rated experience.

RESULTS

SYMPTOM PRESENCE Post-acute anxiety was reported by 18.5% (99 of 534) and depression by 37.4% (199 of 532).

Enhancement motivations: associated with lower odds of depression, compared with recreational use.

Motivational breadth: higher odds of anxiety and depression.

Perceived stigma: higher odds of anxiety and depression.

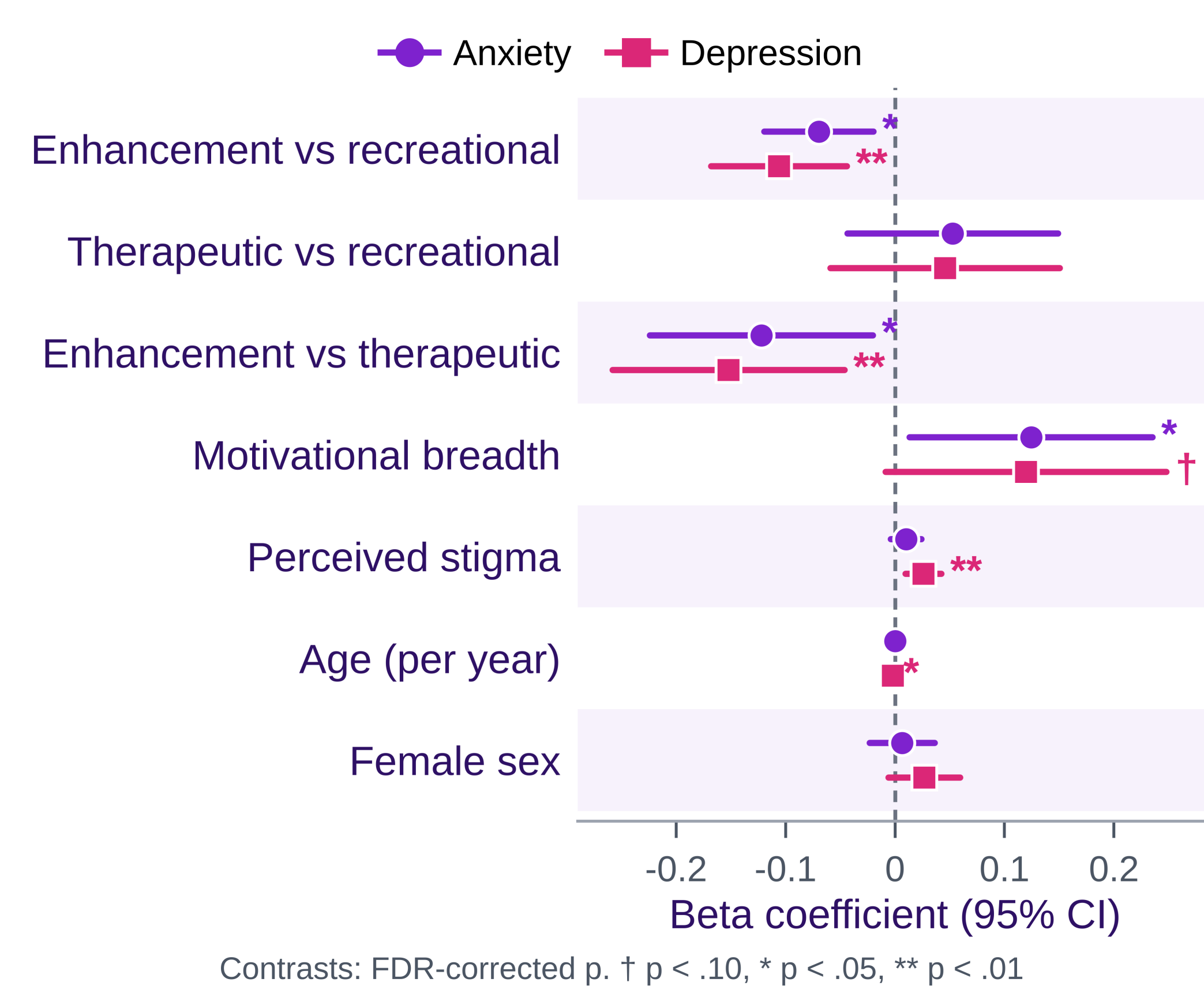
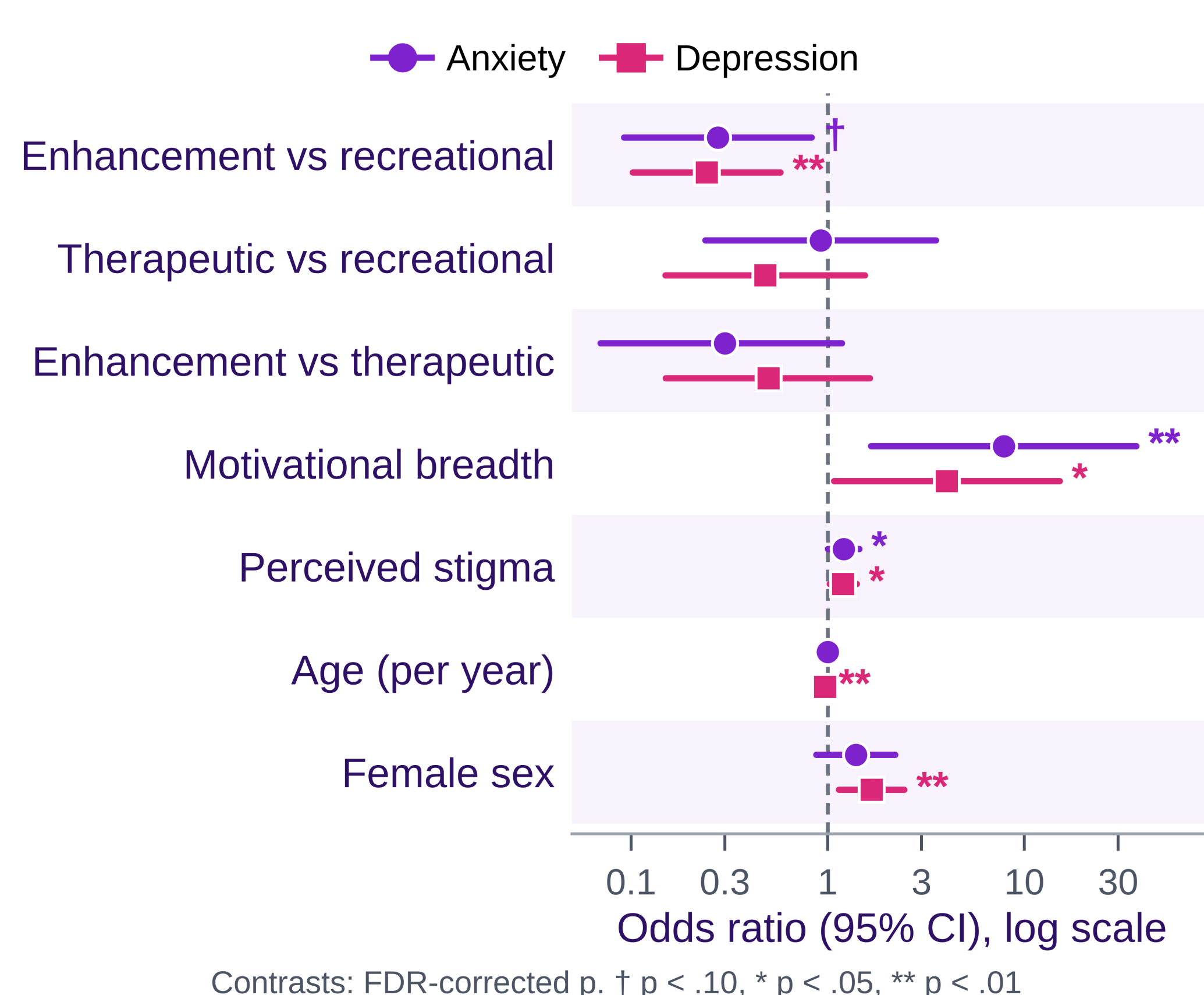
Age and sex: younger age and female sex were associated with depression only.

TOTAL BURDEN Mean burden among symptomatic respondents: 0.37 for anxiety, 0.30 for depression (range 0 to 1).

Enhancement motivations: associated with lower burden of both anxiety and depression, compared with recreational use and with therapeutic motivations.

Motivational breadth: more reasons for use was associated with higher anxiety burden.

Perceived stigma: greater impact of stigma was associated with higher depression burden.



CONCLUSIONS

Why people use psychedelics and how strongly stigma shapes their use were linked to post-acute anxiety and depression. Enhancement-oriented motivations were associated with lower likelihood and burden of depression, whereas broader motivational profiles and greater stigma impact were associated with higher risk.

These findings support psychotherapeutic preparation to shape users' set and intentions, and scientific dissemination to reduce stigma.

Limits: cross-sectional, self-reported, non-representative sample, non-validated index.

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REFERENCES

